

9, Extreme Caution Must Be Exercised When Introducing Commercial Factors as Explanations

Furthermore, the introduction of commerce and trade as an explanatory variable should be strictly limited to those widely acknowledged regimes occupying superior geographical positions within colossal trade networks of pivotal significance in human history. It should absolutely not be applied indiscriminately to regimes with merely average participation in international trade or moderate reliance on commerce.

By applying this filter, we can isolate certain regimes that were clearly prematurely matured (早熟) due to international trade factors. Readers can obviously discern for themselves that many among these fall hopelessly short of being termed **classical states**.

On the eastern segment of the Maritime Silk Road connecting Europe, Asia, and Africa, Southeast Asia—acting as the ultimate crossroads between East and West—benefited tremendously. The Kingdom of Funan (扶南国) was the first formidable power to rise locally (*and also the earliest Southeast Asian state recorded by the Chinese*).

During the centuries after Emperor Wu of Han extended maritime trade to China, navigational technology was not yet sufficient to make bypassing the Malay Peninsula via the Strait of Malacca a lower-cost alternative to transporting goods overland across the Kra Isthmus (克拉地峡). Consequently, Funan prospered by virtue of strangling this vital communication choke point.

However, Funan clearly cannot be considered a **classical state**. By the Tang Dynasty at the latest, advancements in navigational technology rendered the sea route via Malacca overwhelmingly advantageous, leading Funan straight into decline and collapse. The Chenla Kingdom (真腊王国) that annihilated Funan was not a **feudal regime** at all; rather, it was merely a **pre-classical state**. This regime endured a period of fragmentation before reunifying and ultimately forming the Khmer Empire (高棉帝国). It was only at this juncture that the Indochinese Peninsula genuinely entered a **classical society**.

The regime that subsequently replaced Funan and securely perched upon the East-West crossroads due to shifting trade routes was Srivijaya (室利佛势 / 三佛齐). At its zenith, this regime's influence blanketed almost the entire Malay Peninsula and the Sunda Islands, elevating the Malay language to the status of the archipelago's **lingua franca** (四方通语). (*One easily notices that this is a quintessential characteristic of a classical empire. To this day, the most populous ethnic group in Indonesia is the Javanese, whose ethnic language is Javanese; yet the official language of the nation remains Malay*).

However, according to Chinese historical records, right up until the era of Zheng He's voyages to the Western Oceans, the local socio-economic developmental level remained staggeringly backward. Following Srivijaya's decline, the subsequent **feudalization** of maritime Southeast Asia was powerfully propelled by the widespread dissemination of Islam through commerce and missionary activities.

Turning our gaze to the westernmost terminus of the Maritime Silk Road, it is easy to note the Kingdom of Aksum (阿克苏姆王国), situated on the Horn of Africa strangling the Red Sea. This state boasted formidable royal power, constructed massive monumental architecture, and unprecedentedly expanded Ethiopia's borders all the way to Yemen. It promulgated the Ge'ez language

(吉兹语)—classical Ethiopic, functioning as the **lingua franca** of the Horn of Africa—and was one of the earliest states in the world to officially adopt Christianity.

However, observers can also easily discern that this state was glaringly premature compared to classical empires born from normal class transitions. Following the rise of Islam, the **feudalization** process spearheaded by Islam along the East African coast swiftly weakened (*beyond military assaults, stripping away Aksum's dominance over trade was obviously highly critical*) and ultimately annihilated this kingdom. During the several centuries surrounding 1000 AD, the fate of the Ethiopian Christian state was exceedingly grim and ambiguous. It was not until the 13th century, when the Ethiopians retreated into the highland interior and began marching toward a **feudal society**, that they were not only able to halt the Islamic offensive but also empowered the Christians to mount effective counterattacks!

Regimes of this nature also existed at the northernmost reaches of the Eurasian trade routes. An excellent example is the Khazar Khaganate (可萨汗国 / "*Khazar*" is also translated as 哈扎尔 in Chinese), established along the middle and lower reaches of the Volga River. This regime was not only situated on the main artery of the East-West Steppe Silk Road, but also engaged in massive North-South trade at the time—for instance, trafficking slaves from Eastern Europe to the Arab Empire.

The Byzantines had already noticed the stark distinctiveness of the Khazar regime. For example, they widely adopted Judaism, a monotheistic religion (*though highly likely confined to the aristocracy*), and their cities were relatively developed. Thus, they were deemed "the most civilized branch among all the Turkic peoples."

But this obviously does not mean the Khazar Khaganate was a **classical state**! After this regime was obliterated by the Rus' people, the local region rapidly reverted to a fragmented landscape of nomadic tribes. As for the lucrative trade routes upon which the Khazar Khaganate thrived, they flourished once again three or four centuries later during the rule of the Golden Horde (*as part of the Pax Mongolica*). However, they plummeted into decline following Timur's invasions, and were entirely abandoned following the opening of the New Sea Routes (新航路开辟 / Age of Discovery).

In the distant south, the Black empires that arose in the Sahel region following the first wave of Islamization exhibited highly pronounced **classical characteristics**. If the Mali Empire (*assuming it is even appropriate to call it an empire*) was still too primitive, then the Songhai Empire (桑海帝国) much more closely resembled a West African **classical empire** (*though, as I will elucidate later, I do not believe it was a true classical empire either*).

The Songhai people and the Mali people were separated by over 1,000 kilometers, situated respectively along the lower and upper reaches of the Niger River's bend. However, during the process where the Songhai people declared independence from Mali and ultimately superseded it (*superseding its dominant ruling status, without actually annihilating the latter*), the entire region neither regressed into a fragmented landscape of tribes and primitive states, nor did it enter the **feudalization** phase. Instead, the Songhai people inherited the political legacy of the Mali Empire and further perfected its political institutions. For example, the Songhai Empire introduced standardized systems of weights and measures, established a professional standing army (职业常备军), and exerted vastly stronger central administrative control over the localities than the previous era.

Although the southward invasion by the Moroccans triggered the collapse of the Songhai Empire, as previously stated, the **feudalization** of the Sahel belt did not commence immediately thereafter, and traditional mega-cities like Timbuktu and Djenné (杰内) indeed never recovered from the devastation.

This process indisputably proves that the core factor underpinning the establishment of a **classical empire** along the middle reaches of the Niger River back then was indeed the trans-Saharan trade. When this factor eventually vanished, the developmental level of the local society had fundamentally not yet reached the stage of **Late Antiquity** (古典晚期).

Following the opening of the New Sea Routes by the Portuguese, the trans-Saharan trade shifted eastward. Between the 11th and 13th centuries, a cluster of city-states sequentially emerged in the Hausa (豪萨) region. Further east, in the Chad region, the trans-Saharan trade might have emerged even earlier due to geographical reasons (*though there seemingly existed no high-value commodities worth mentioning for exchange here; the western regions later surpassed them via the gold-salt trade*). Consequently, early states emerged here by the 8th century at the latest.

Riding the prosperity of the eastern trans-Saharan trade routes, following the zenith of the Songhai Empire, the Bornu Empire (博尔努帝国) situated in the Lake Chad basin entered its golden age. This regime primarily exported slaves, treating the Ottoman Empire—which had conquered North Africa—as its major trading partner.

Historical data indicates that the rulers of Bornu conspicuously lacked the desire to expand their territory and spread Islam to the peripheral (*southern*) tribes and minor kingdoms that still adhered to indigenous religions. This was because the rulers needed to harvest a steady supply of slaves from those regions! **This is glaringly a pre-feudal consciousness.** (*Though, because this regime was exceedingly rudimentary, it could hardly be considered a classical empire either*).

The Hausa city-states similarly benefited from the eastward shift of the trans-Saharan trade routes. The sustained social progress of this region was guaranteed, and it ultimately became the epicenter of the **feudalizing** Islamic Jihads in West Africa.

The myriad examples cited above are sufficient to illustrate that the specific circumstances under which commercial trade triggered local societal prematurity (早熟)—leading to the emergence of classical characteristics or even precocious entry into the classical period—were exceedingly complex and defy sweeping generalizations.

Furthermore, readers can easily discern that **no matter how developed commerce and trade might be, they can absolutely never assist a state in executing a structural leap in social stages!** After these ascendant great powers met their end, let alone advancing into the **feudal stage**, some local societies completely regressed back to the level of early states, or even devolved entirely into tribal states!

These stark historical facts serve as a solemn warning: **While incorporating commerce and trade as a corrective factor is profoundly necessary, overestimating their impact and abusing this explanation is intellectually toxic!**

9, 引入商贸因素解释需要十分谨慎

另外，引入商业和贸易这一解释应当限制在那些公认的，在人类历史上举足轻重的庞大贸易网络中占据优越地理位置的政权，而不考虑那些参与国际贸易程度以及对商业的依赖程度一般的政权。这样我

们就可以筛选出一些显然因为国际贸易因素而较为早熟的政权，读者显然自己也能分辨出这其中不少远不能称为古典国家。在连接欧亚非的海上丝绸之路的东段，东南亚作为东西方的十字路口受益颇丰，扶南国是当地崛起的第一个强国（也是中国人记录最早的东南亚国家）。在汉武帝将海上贸易延伸到中国之后的几个世纪中，航海技术还不足以让绕过马来半岛经由马六甲海峡成为比在陆地上穿过克拉地峡成本更低的选择，扶南因此凭借扼守交通要道的优势兴旺。但是扶南显然还无法算一个古典国家，因为至迟到唐代，航海技术的发展已经使经由马六甲的海路变得极具优势，扶南因此走向衰亡。灭亡扶南的真腊王国非但不是一个封建政权，反而只是一个前古典的国家，这个政权经历了一段时间的分裂期，再统一之后最终形成了高棉帝国，此时中南半岛才进入真正意义的古典社会。

而因为贸易路线转移而取代扶南安坐东西十字路口上的政权是室利佛势（Srivijaya，三佛齐），这个政权鼎盛的时候势力几乎遍及马来半岛和巽他群岛，使马来语成为列岛的“四方通语”（人们很容易注意到这就是古典帝国的特征之一，直到今天印度尼西亚人口最多的民族是爪哇族，其民族语言是爪哇语，但是该国的官方语言仍旧是马来语），但是直到郑和下西洋的年代，按中国的历史记载来看当地的社会发展水平仍然极其落后。在三佛齐衰亡后随后发生的海岛东南亚的封建化是伊斯兰教随着商业和传教活动广泛传播有力推动的。把目光转向海上丝绸之路的最西头，人们很容易注意到立于非洲之角扼守红海的阿克苏姆王国（Aksum），这个国家王权强盛，修建了大量的纪念碑建筑，并且空前绝后地将埃塞俄比亚的疆域扩张到也门。它推行了吉兹语（是古典埃塞俄比亚语，非洲之角的“四方通语”），是最早接纳基督教的国家之一。但是观察者也很容易看出这个国家显然比起正常阶级交替产生的古典帝国太过早熟，自伊斯兰教兴起之后，东非沿岸伊斯兰教主导的封建化进程迅速削弱（除了军事进攻以外，显然夺去贸易的主导权也是很重要的）并最终消灭了这个国家。在公元1000年前后的几个世纪里，埃塞俄比亚基督教国家的命运晦暗不明，直到13世纪开始，向高原腹地退却的埃塞俄比亚人开始走向封建社会，这不但阻挡了伊斯兰教的攻势并且使基督徒有能力反击。

在欧亚贸易路线的最北方一样存在这样的政权，例如立国于伏尔加河中下游的可萨汗国（“Khazar”在汉语里的另一种翻译是哈扎尔），这个政权不但位于东西向的草原丝绸之路的干线上，在当年同时也存在大规模的南北贸易，例如从东欧贩卖奴隶到阿拉伯帝国。拜占庭人就已经注意到可萨人政权的显著不同，例如他们广泛信仰犹太教这个一神教（不过大概率也只是贵族），城市较为发达，因此是“所有突厥人中最文明的一支”。但这显然不意味着可萨汗国就是一个古典国家，这个政权在被罗斯人摧毁之后，当地很快又重新回到了游牧部落林立的状态。至于可萨汗国赖以兴盛的贸易商路，在三四个世纪之后的金帐汗国统治时期又一次繁荣起来（作为蒙古治下的和平的一部分），但是随着帖木儿的入侵再次衰落，新航路开辟之后被完全废弃。

在遥远的南方，在第一次伊斯兰化进程之后崛起的萨赫勒地区黑人帝国的古典特征就非常明显，如果说马里帝国（如果称为帝国合适的话）还太过原始，那么桑海帝国就更像一个西非的古典帝国（但是在后面我会说明我并不认为它真的是一个古典帝国）。桑海人与马里人相距超过1000公里，分别位于尼日尔河河曲地区的下游和上游，但是当桑海人从马里独立并最终取代马里（取代马里的统治地位，并没有灭掉后者）的过程中，整个地区不是退回到部落和原始国家林立的状态，也不是进入封建化阶段，桑海人继承了马里帝国的政治遗产并使得政治制度更加完善。例如桑海帝国引入了统一的度量衡制，设立了职业常备军，中央对地方的行政管理比前代更强。虽然摩洛哥人的南侵使桑海帝国崩溃，但是萨赫勒带的封建化如前所述也并非立刻就展开，并且廷巴克图和杰内这样的传统大城的确一蹶不振。这个过程说明当年支撑尼日尔河中游建立起一个古典帝国的核心因素的确是跨撒哈拉贸易，当这个因素最终消失的时候当地社会的发展程度还并没有达到古典晚期的水平。

在葡萄牙人开辟新航路之后，跨撒哈拉贸易向东转移。豪萨地区在公元11到13世纪之间陆续兴起了一批城邦国家。更东的乍得地区可能因为地理原因跨撒哈拉贸易兴起的更早（但是这里似乎没有值得一提的高价值商品交换，西部地区因为金盐贸易后来居上了），因此在最晚公元八世纪时就出现了早期国家。随着撒哈拉贸易东线的繁荣，继桑海帝国（的盛期）之后位于乍得湖区的博尔努帝国（Bornu）进入极盛期，这个政权以攻占北非的奥斯曼帝国为主要的贸易伙伴出口奴隶。资料显示博尔努的统治者缺少将版图和伊斯兰教扩张到周边（南方）仍然信仰原始宗教的部落和小王国的欲望，因为统治者需要稳定地从那里获得奴隶，这显然是一种前封建时期的意识（不过这个政权因为过于简单也算不上古典帝国）。豪萨城邦同样也受惠于跨撒哈拉商路的东移，该地区持久的社会进步得到保证，并最终成为西非封建化伊斯兰圣战的策源地。上述诸多例子足以说明商业贸易导致当地社会早熟，出现古典时期特征甚

至提前进入古典时期的具体情况十分复杂，难以一概而论。而且读者也很容易看到，再发达的商业和贸易也不可能帮助一个国家践行社会阶段的跃迁，这些兴起的大国在结束之后当地社会不要说进入封建阶段，有的甚至退回到早期国家的水平甚至是部落状态。这些事实告诫人们，虽然加入商业和贸易这个修正十分必要的，但是高估其影响而滥用它则是有害的。